

How Your Body Language Can Tell People You're a Leader—or Not

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Nonverbal communication from executives can speak volumes to employees and others. For starters, don't tilt your head.



One type of nonverbal communication, 'steepling' with your hands, can convey quickly to an audience that you are confident.

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For better or worse, C-suite leaders are always on display. And whether in a one-on-one meeting or speaking to a crowd of thousands, they are sending nonverbal messages that shape employees' opinions of whether they are authentic and credible.

New research shows that striking the right balance of power and authority with warmth and empathy is essential. If executives' body language conveys too many power signals, they appear aloof. But too much warmth can prevent them from setting themselves apart and commanding the attention of others.

Here are some of the most important cues:

Head straight. When speaking to crowds large or small, a leader should hold his or her head straight and avoid tilting it or cocking it to either side, says Carol Kinsey Goman, an executive coach and author of the book "The Silent Language of Leaders." The head can be tilted slightly back, but not too much; otherwise, the person may come across as arrogant.

Growing smile. Smiles should be used sparingly because too much smiling makes one seem weak. The most effective smile is one that starts small but grows when a person walks into a room or walks across a stage, Ms. Goman says.